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China's geopolitical oil strategy in the Andean region

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This chapter discusses China's oil dependency and its effect on the Andean region. My hypothesis is that one of the objective limits to Chinese development is found precisely in its oil dependency. This limitation consequently drives the need to gain access to these resources, which, in turn, has caused changes in the Ecuadorian economy and society, particularly that which is dependent on petroleum. In order to be able to understand how this dialectic arises between the dependency on buying oil and Ecuadorian dependence on its sale, the chapter is composed of two parts: while the first part reviews the characteristics and conditions of Chinese development, the second part considers the case of Ecuador. Consistent with the object of inquiry, I give special attention to the variables of work, environment and economy in analysing both China and Ecuador.

The emergence of China in the international order cannot be explained as marginal to its long history, during which one of its main comparative advantages has been the uncommon development of its workforce. Chinese agricultural systems are among the most ancient on the planet; this can be seen in the use of irrigation, rice cultivation and in the social organisation capable of sustaining a highly skilled population for social production. Huge engineering works allowed China to consolidate the bases of a thriving agricultural society. In order to flood enormous rice fields, the empire and Chinese people were capable of changing the course of the Yellow River. This type of work was repeated on various occasions through the diversion of major rivers. Besides supplying the population, the works were able to integrate a vast and diverse territory in order to create a